‘The idea was to create a *nukkad* [street corner] Parliament,’ is how Prashant Kishore of Citizens for Accountable Governance (CAG) which executed the Chai pe Charcha concept describes it. A chai stall is, after all, omnipresent across the country. From a small village to a sprawling metropolis, having a cup of tea was a universal Indian experience. Now, Modi would be identified with it.

There was also another, less obvious, reason behind the idea. In early February, the Aam Aadmi Party’s popularity had peaked. The AAP was making the headlines across the country by taking its politics to the street and directly communicating with the voter. The AAP had also launched a sustained attack on Modi’s proximity to corporate India, suggesting that he was a ‘*khaas* aadmi’ who was disconnected with the ‘real India’, an attack potentially far more damaging to Modi than the Congress trotting out shopworn secularism shibboleths. ‘We were acutely aware of what the AAP was doing and needed our own bit of street theatre to combat the AAP’s communication strategy,’ says a BJP leader.

Chai pe Charcha was the perfect answer to correct any impression that Modi was not an ‘aam aadmi’. A tea stall where a potential prime minister sits with his fellow citizens drinking chai—what could be a greater equalizer? There was always, of course, the subtext of Modi having grown up in poverty that would also play out. Team Modi, it appeared, had hit upon another winning formula. Mani Shankar Aiyar’s unwise snobbery had been superbly marketed to win public sympathy for the so-called social pariah.

Ironically, on the many occasions I had chatted with Modi, I had never heard him speak about selling tea at a railway station. In fact, in all his political campaigns as Gujarat chief minister, Modi had never referred to his early years in Vadnagar. His politics had always been fashioned around the present and the future, not about his past. A senior Gujarat journalist told me the tea story was, in fact, bogus. ‘*Sab jhoot hai, unhone koi chai nahi bechi’* (It’s all a lie, he never sold any tea), he told me confidently.

But Modi’s younger brother Prahlad insists that the brothers did help their father who ran a tea stall near the Vadnagar railway station. ‘Our